Ti puka ale sikana ni o **Mitaeme**, isi

eme ke pei patai pa **Elia** o-ke ta

pesin hafe yi eme pa-ke niau cian

i patai kinonia a ta tunia.

# CONSONANTS & VOWELS

Mitaeme features **twelve consonants**. In this textbook, the letter used to write each consonant will be included between angle brackets, , while the pronunciation will be written in the International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA) and placed between forward slashes, /.../. For each sound, we will provide a rough example in Standard American English.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| ⟨m⟩ /m/<br>“mail” | ⟨n⟩ /n/<br>“nail” | | |
| ⟨p⟩ /p/<br>“pin” | ⟨t⟩ /t/<br>“tin” | ⟨c⟩ /t͡ʃ ~ ʃ/<br>“chin” ~ “shin” | ⟨k⟩ /k/<br>“kin” |
| ⟨f⟩ /ɸ ~ f/<br>“fed” | ⟨s⟩ /s/<br>“said” | | ⟨h⟩ /x ~ h/<br>“head” |
| ⟨w⟩ /w ~ v/<br>“wack” | ⟨l⟩ /l/<br>“lack” | ⟨y⟩ /j/<br>“yak” | |

In addition to these, there are **five vowels**. Two examples are given: first in Standard American English and then in Spanish, as the five vowels of Mitaeme do not align well with those in English but align perfectly with those in Spanish (or Japanese, Tamil, and so on).

| | |
|---|---|
| ⟨i⟩ /i/<br>“leak”<br>“pira” | ⟨u⟩ /u/<br>“boot”<br>“curso” |
| ⟨e⟩ /e/<br>“speck”<br>“pero” | ⟨o⟩ /o/<br>“boat”<br>“corso” |
| ⟨a⟩ /a/<br>“hand”<br>“casa” | |

If you can’t quite pronounce each of these letters at first, don’t worry! They should come naturally with a little practice. Try listening to recordings of the pronunciation of Spanish, Tamil, Indonesian, or Tagalog vowels.

# SPELLING

All sounds in Mitaeme are written with exactly one letter, and each letter is only ever pronounced exactly one way—with the slight exception of /j/ and /w/.

In a syllable, when /j/ or /w/ appear after a consonant or vowel, they are written ⟨i⟩ and ⟨u⟩ respectively. Thus, /koj/ is written ⟨koi⟩ and /t͡ʃjaw/ is written ⟨ciau⟩.

However, across syllables, this rule does not apply, so /an.ja/ is written ⟨anya⟩ instead of *⟨ania⟩.

This helps the reader distinguish between ⟨anya⟩ /an.ja/ and ⟨ania⟩ /a.nja/ which would otherwise both be written the same. This becomes important for recognizing the different parts of compound words.

Finally, /n/ is written ⟨m⟩ and pronounced as /m/ whenever it appears before /m/, /p/, or /w/. Thus, you can have a word like ⟨kompiuta⟩ /kom.pju.ta/ but never *⟨konpiuta⟩.

## The R-Sound

Mitaeme features one extra sound that, as a rule, never appears in general vocabulary. It is only ever used for proper names of people, places, cultures, etc. This sound is ⟨r⟩ /ɾ/ which is pronounced like the 'r' in Spanish "pero" or, in most American English dialects, the 'tt' in "butter."

This sound only exists so that Mitaeme can borrow words like मराठी (marāṭhī) as ⟨Marati⟩ and Росси́я (Rossíja) as ⟨Rasiya⟩.

## Punctuation

The first letter of each sentence is capitalized: ⟨M N P T C K F S H W L Y R⟩ and ⟨I E A U O⟩. In addition, proper names may be capitalized.

The period, ⟨.⟩, is used at the end of sentences. The exclamation mark, ⟨!⟩, may be used for exclamatory phrases and interjections! And the question mark, ⟨?⟩, is used at the end of questions.

Finally, the hyphen, ⟨-⟩, is used between the different parts of a compound word. When a word is common and relatively unambiguous, the hyphen may be dropped, as in ⟨motosaikale⟩, "motorcycle." Conversely, some highly-frequent adjective-noun pairs such as the pronoun, ⟨ta ni⟩ "y'all," may appear hyphenated: ⟨ta-ni⟩.

# EXTRA: SYLLABLES

Mitaeme features **seventeen** unique sounds. However, instead of going one-by-one through these, we are going to lay out the four parts of a syllable and the different sounds that can appear in each. These parts include: twelve **initials** (ω), two **medials** (μ), five **vowels** (ν), and one **final** (κ).

The syllable in Mitaeme is structured like so:

| Initial | 1st Medial | Vowel | 2nd Medial | Final |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ω | μ | ν | μ | κ |
| { m n p t c k f s h w l y } | { i u } | { i e a u o } | { i u } | { n } |

Importantly, there are a few restrictions on syllable structure which narrow down the number of possibilities:

1. The first medial may only appear when there is an initial, but it cannot appear when that initial is ⟨y⟩ or ⟨w⟩. So ⟨kia⟩ but never *⟨yia⟩.

2. The same letter may never appear twice, next to each other, in the same syllable. In other words, neither the first nor second medial can be ⟨i⟩ when the vowel is ⟨i⟩. Similarly, neither medial can be ⟨u⟩ when the vowel is ⟨u⟩. So, ⟨kia⟩ but never *⟨kii⟩ , and ⟨kua⟩ but never *⟨kuu⟩.

3. If there is a first medial, the syllable may only have a second medial or a final, never both. So ⟨kiau⟩ or ⟨kian⟩ but never *⟨kiaun⟩.

4. The sequences ⟨iu⟩ and ⟨ui⟩ always represent a medial followed by vowel, never a vowel followed by a medial.

5. Before ⟨m⟩, ⟨p⟩, and ⟨w⟩, the final is ⟨n⟩ written and pronounced as ⟨m⟩. So ⟨kompu⟩ but never *⟨konpu⟩. Similarly, the final ⟨n⟩ is pronounced like the 'ng' in "sing" when it appears before ⟨k⟩, but its spelling remains the same.

6. Lastly, a non-compound word cannot contain a syllable ending in a vowel followed by a syllable beginning with a vowel. So, ⟨kahe⟩ but never *⟨kae⟩.

Altogether, these rules mean that the total number of possible syllables in Mitaeme is around **462** and each syllable is never more than **4** sounds long. In addition, the spelling of a word is never ambiguous: you always know how to pronounce a word given its spelling and vice versa.

# PRACTICE 1: SPELLING

YI OSA | YI OSA | YI OSA | YI OSA | YI OSA | YI OSA
WANINA SOUNDS

# DIALOGUE & VOCABULARY

**Yan A:** Kai tali!

**Yan B:** Kai tali! Ni te men ma?

**Yan A:** Man te men Erin. I ni?

**Yan B:** Man te men Kuancin. Ni famwen teke ma-meta?

**Yan A:** Man teke Kalifonia. Ni katiki a ti ma?

**Yan B:** Na, man te kasa a Peicin.

**Person A:** Hello!

**Person B:** Hello! What is your name?

**Person A:** My name is Erin. And you?

**Person B:** My name is Guangxin. Where are you visiting from?

**Person A:** I am from California. Do you live here?

**Person B:** No, my home is in Beijing.

| Vocabulary | Pronunciation | Part of Speech | Meaning | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| kai tali | /kaj ta.li/ | interj. | greetings, hello | |
| man | /man/ | pron. | I, me | 1SG |
| ni | /ni/ | pron. | you (1) | 2SG |
| ye | /je/ | pron. | they, she, he (1) | 3SG |
| ta man | /ta.man/ | pron. | we, us | 1PL |
| ta ni | /ta.ni/ | pron. | you (2+) | 2PL |
| ta ye | /ta.je/ | pron. | they (2+) | 3PL |
| men | /men/ | n. | name | |
| kasa | /ka.sa/ | n. | house, home | |
| famwen | /fam.wen/ | v. | to visit | |
| katiki | /ka.ti.ki/ | v. | to live | |
| ti | /ti/ | adj. | this | PROX |
| yena | /je.na/ | adj. | that (near) | MEDI |
| akeli | /a.ke.li/ | adj. | that (far) | DIST |
| a | /a/ | prep. | at, on, to | |
| teke | /te.ke/ | prep. | from, of, out of | |
| te | /te/ | part. | genitive | GEN |
| ma | /ma/ | part. | interrogative | INT |
| i | /i/ | part. | coordinator | COORD |

# FREE WORDS

## Free Parts of Speech

Words never change form. There are no prefixes or suffixes and no changes to roots.

A language like English will sometimes use affixes to indicate grammatical features—we often make a noun plural in this way: “car” to “cars,” where the suffix ‘-s’ indicates the plural form. Similarly, we sometimes make changes to the root: “mouse” to “mice.”

Mitaeme never does this. Instead, extra words are added to sentences to convey more complex meaning. Words may either be **free**, not relying on other words to appear, or **bound**, relying on other words. There are three basic types of free words:

A **verb** refers to an action, occurrence, or state: “to know,” “to have,” “to understand,” and so on.

Ta-man **ale** a kasa.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| ta-man | **ale** | a | kasa |
| we | **go** | to | house |

We are going to the house.

An **adjective** refers to a quality: “green,” “blue,” “heavy,” “good,” “old,” and so on. Adjectives may also act as adverbs, when semantically applicable. Adjectives always appear directly before the word they modify.

Ti **umai** kafe.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| ti | **umai** | kafe |
| this | **delicious** | coffee |

This is delicious coffee.

A **noun** refers to a person, place, thing, or concept: “woman,” “garden,” “spoon,” “beauty,” and so on. Nouns also include pronouns like “I,” “you,” and “they.”

**Ni** tinke **palu**.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **ni** | tinke | **palu** |
| **you** | drink | **milk** |

You are drinking milk.

## Bound Parts of Speech

There are two additional parts of speech that can only appear when they are attached to another word or phrase: prepositions and particles.

A **preposition** creates a relationship between a noun and other parts of the sentence. Usually, this relationship has to do with location, time, direction, or manner. Prepositions are words like "in," "at," "on," "while," and so on. Prepositions always appear before the noun, with other words like adjectives and possessors that modify the same noun appearing between the preposition and the modified word.

Ta-ye ale **a** ca-kasa **teke** kasa.

| | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| ta-ye | ale | **a** | aiki-meta | **teke** | kasa | |
| they (2+) | | go | **to** | workplace | **from** | home |

They are going to work from home.

**Particles** add information and connect phrases. In Mitaeme, this includes words like "no," "that," "and," as well as possessive and question markers. Particles can appear at the beginning of ends of sentences or before the verb they modify, with adverbs placed between the particle and verb.

Ye **te** auto **le** osoi ale **ma**?

| | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| ye | **te** | auto | **le** | osoi | ale | **ma** |
| they | **GEN** | car | **PST** | slow | go | **INT** |

Did their car go slowly?

## Te – The Genitive Particle

The particle, ⟨te⟩, marks the "genitive"—appearing after a noun and indicating possession, origin, or composition. The possessor is the modified noun, with the possessee appearing after the particle.

In English, we usually indicate the possessive meaning by writing "-'s" as in "the dog's tail" or by using the preposition "of" as in "the house of the doctor." In Mitaeme, this is achieved by placing ⟨te⟩ between the possessor and what is possessed.

Ti man te cota kasa.

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ti | man | te | cota | kasa |
| this | I | GEN | small | house |

This is my small house.

Like “of,” ⟨te⟩ can be used to indicate composition as in: “a boat (made) of wood.” In addition, this can indicate what a container is filled with.

Yena cala te piala.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| yena | cala | te | piala |
| that | water | GEN | cup |

That is a cup of water.

Akeli lennio te kasa.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| akeli | lennio | te | kasa |
| that | wood | GEN | house |

That is a house (made) of wood.

Finally, ⟨te⟩ can indicate origin. This is similar to the “from” in English phrases such as “the person from Quebec” or “the woman from Spain.”

Ye Epania te yan.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| ye | Epania | te | yan |
| they | Spain | GEN | person |

They are a Spanish person.

Man Intonesia te.

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| man | Intonesia | te |
| I | Indonesia | GEN |

I am Indonesian.

## Ma – The Interrogative Particle

Questions always contain the particle ⟨ma⟩, which marks the sentence as such.

⟨Ma⟩ may also be compounded with nouns to form question words like “what” or “how.” For example, ⟨ma-meta⟩ “where” sees ⟨ma⟩ combined with ⟨meta⟩ “place.” Similarly, ⟨ma-aika⟩ “when” sees it combined with ⟨aika⟩ “time.” Any noun may be combined with ⟨ma⟩ to form the meaning “which / what ___.” For example, ⟨imahen⟩ “picture” becomes ⟨ma-imahen⟩ “which picture.”

Ni le ale a ma-kasa?

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ni | le | ale | a | ma-kasa |
| you | PST | go | to | INT-house |

Which house did you go to?

## I – The Coordinating Conjunction

The coordinating conjunction, ⟨i⟩, is used like “and” to connect nouns, phrases, and sentences.

Man le ale a satu-kasa i pai wino.

| | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| man | le | ale | a | satu-kasa | i | pai | wino |
| I | PST | go | to | store | and | buy | wine |

I went to the store and bought wine.

# PRACTICE 2: PARTS OF SPEECH

# DIALOGUE & VOCABULARY

**Yan A:** Koi koi! Man na iya tinke man te ca na o-ke ye sahin.

**Person A:** Excuse me! I cannot drink my tea because it is hot.

**Yan B:** A! Man ale pana palu o-ke citala-hase ye.

**Person B:** Oh! I will go get milk in order to cool it down.

**Yan A:** Koi koi.

**Person A:** Thank you.

**Yan B:** Ti-so. Samaha man.

**Person B:** Here you go. I'm sorry.

**Yan A:** Na pentin. Man ale pai keike tampien, koi koi. Ni te keike kai umai.

**Person A:** It's nothing. I will also buy cake, please. Your cake is very tasty.

**Yan B:** So so. Man kome hafe ni te keike.

**Person B:** Of course. I'll bring your cake.

| Vocabulary | Pronunciation | Part of Speech | Meaning |
|---|---|---|---|
| koi | /koj/ | interj. | please, thank you, excuse me |
| ti-so | /ti.so/ | interj. | here you go, there you go |
| ca | /t͡ʃa/ | n. | tea |
| palu | /pa.lu/ | n. | milk |
| keike | /kej.ke/ | n. | cake |
| hase | /ha.se/ | v. | to do, to make |
| iya | /i.ja/ | v. | to be able, to know how to |
| kome | /ko.me/ | v. | to come |
| hafe | /ha.fe/ | v. | to have, to possess |
| tinke | /tiŋ.ke/ | v. | to drink |
| samaha | /sa.ma.ha/ | v. | to forgive, to pardon |
| kai | /kaj/ | adj. | many, much, often |
| sahin | /sa.hin/ | adj. | hot, warm, heated |
| citala | /t͡ʃi.ta.la/ | adj. | cold, cool, cooled |
| umai | /u.maj/ | adj. | tasty, delicious |
| pentin | /pen.tin/ | adj. | important, key, major |
| o | /o/ | prep. | for, about, in order to |
| ke | /ke/ | part. | that, relativizer REL |
| so | /so/ | part. | yes, affirmative AFF |
| na | /na/ | part. | no, negative NEG |

# WORD ORDER

## Basic Sentence Structure

...